Topic 11 — Ancient Indian Administration

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Ancient Rulers · Titles of Ancient Rulers · Rulers and their Inscriptions · Ancient Administration
Taught in time-order: Vedic → Magadha → Maurya → Post-Mauryan → Gupta → Harsha. This file is the **title / inscription / official match-list**.

Sources baked in: edicts, Prayag, Hathigumpha, Arthashastra, *Indica*, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — Agronomai, Bhagadugha, Dhamma-mahamatra, inscription pairs **Last verified:** August 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Administration Sources

Short source table | fuller Mauryan literature list is in Topic 7

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Arthashastra (अर्थशास्त्र)	**Kautilya / Chanakya**	Saptanga, adhyakshas, spies, revenue
Indica	**Megasthenes** (मेगस्थनीज)	Agronomai, city boards, seven classes

- Do not treat *Indica* as the *Arthashastra*.
- Broader Mauryan book–writer pairs sit in Topic 7.

11.1 Ancient Rulers

Time-order spine | titles and inscriptions in the next two headings

- The Vedic start is the **rajan** (राजन). He is a tribal chief, not an emperor. Magadha houses then run Haryanka, Shishunaga, and Nanda.
- Haryanka names to keep are **Bimbisara** and **Ajatashatru** (अजातशत्रु). Nanda names to keep are **Mahapadma** and **Dhana**.
- The first pan-north machine is **Chandragupta Maurya**, about **322 BCE**. Then come **Bindusara** and **Ashoka**. The empire ends in **185 BCE** when **Pushyamitra Shunga** (पुष्यमित्र शुंग) kills Brihadratha.
- Post-Mauryan names papers keep include **Pushyamitra**, **Kharavela** of Kalinga, **Kanishka** the Kushan, and **Gautamiputra Satakarni** in the Deccan.
- Gupta line in order: Sri Gupta → Ghatotkacha → **Chandragupta I** → **Samudragupta** → **Chandragupta II** → Kumaragupta I → **Skandagupta**.
- The last ancient north reunion is **Harsha** of the Pushyabhuti house, **606–647**. The capital shifts from Thanesar to Kannauj.

- The best ID for a king is his **inscription**. Coins come next. Puranas come last.

Kind	Examples	use
Literary	Veda, Purana, Tripitaka, Sangam	doctrine, inflated king-lists
Epigraphy	edicts, Hathigumpha, Prayag, Nasik, Mehrauli	hardest dates and titles
Numismatics	punch-mark, Kushan gold, CG II silver	2022 Shaka-victory proof
Archaeology	sites, C-14, PGW / NBPW / IVC	period, not a king's name
Foreign accounts	Megasthenes, Fa-Hien, Xuanzang, I-tsing	2024 traveller order

Coins as administrative evidence

Coin type	Period / issuer	What it proves
Punch-marked silver (*karshapana*)	Mahajanapada → Maurya	Urban trade, magistrate control, weight standard
Mauryan cast copper	Mauryan	State issue beyond silver punch-marks
Indo-Greek portrait	Menander etc.	Die-struck bilingual (Greek + Kharoshthi) kings
Kushan gold	Vima / Kanishka	Imperial titles, **Devaputra**, long-distance trade
Satavahana lead / bronze	Deccan	**Ship** types = sea trade; metronymic legends
Gupta gold dinara	Samudragupta → Skandagupta	Imperial titles; **Chandragupta II** silver = western **Shaka** victory
Restruck Nahapana silver	Gautamiputra age	Defeat of western Shaka overlord

- Coins name kings when inscriptions are absent. They show **titles**, **deities**, and **mint control**. They do **not** replace edicts for law and welfare policy.
- The **Vishnu Purana** carries Maurya genealogy. Only statement 1 is true.
- The Vayu Purana is **not** a Gupta admin manual.

> **Logic:** Chandragupta Maurya is not Chandragupta I. Chandragupta I is not Chandragupta II.

11.2 Titles of Ancient Rulers

Title is not the personal name | match each king to his stamp

Ancient papers often ask a **title**, not a personal name. Hold the pairs below as separate sentences.

Vedic and Nanda

- The Vedic chief is **Rajan** (राजन).

- A Later Vedic wider claim is **Samrat** (सम्राट) or **Ekarat** (एकराट्).
- **Mahapadma Nanda** is **Ekarat** (एकराट्) and **Sarvakshatrantaka** (सर्वक्षत्रान्तक).

Mauryan

- **Chandragupta Maurya** is Greek **Sandrokottos**.
- **Bindusara** is **Amitraghata** (अमित्रघात) / **Amitrochates**.
- **Ashoka** is **Devanampiya Piyadassi** (देवानांप्रिय प्रियदर्शी) on most edicts.
- His personal name appears at **Maski**, then at Gujarra, Nittur, and Udegolam.

Post-Mauryan

- **Kanishka** is **Devaputra** (देवपुत्र).
- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** is **Dakshinapathapati** (दक्षिणापथपति).
- **Kharavela** is **Mahameghavahana** (महामेघवाहन) of the Chedi line.
- **Rudradaman I** is **Mahakshatrapa** (महाक्षत्रप).

Gupta and Harsha

- **Sri Gupta** and **Ghatotkacha** are **Maharaja** (महाराज) only.
- **Chandragupta I** is the first Gupta **Maharajadhiraja** (महाराजाधिराज).
- **Samudragupta** is Maharajadhiraja and *kaviraja* (कविराज). Digvijaya is the **policy**, not a coin-title.
- **Chandragupta II** is **Vikramaditya** (विक्रमादित्य).
- **Kumaragupta I** is **Mahendraditya** (महेन्द्रादित्य).
- **Skandagupta** is **Kramaditya** (क्रमादित्य) or Vikramaditya on some types.
- **Harsha** is Chinese **Siladitya** (शीलादित्य). He is also Paramabhattaraka (परमभट्टारक).
- A Gupta or Harsha feudatory is **Samanta** (सामंत) or **Mahasamanta** (महासामंत).
- **Chakravartin** (चक्रवर्ती) is the ideal wheel-turning monarch. It is not one king's exclusive stamp.
- Title inflation grows from Gupta grants onward.

> **Logic:** Vikramaditya is not Samudragupta. Devanampiya is not Harsha.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q29

With reference to the Puranas, which one of the following statements is correct?

1. Information about the Mauryan dynasty is found in the Vishnu Purana.
2. Vayu Purana throws light on the Gupta system of governance.

A. Only 1 B. Only 2 C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Show answer

Ans: A — Only 1. Vishnu Purana has Mauryas. Vayu ≠ Gupta admin.

11.3 Rulers and their Inscriptions

King ↔ inscription pairs | do not swap look-alike stones

Each ruler below is tied to one famous inscription. Hold the pair as a full sentence.

Mauryan and early

- **Ashoka** issues Major and Minor Rock Edicts and Pillar edicts. The personal name is rare. It appears at **Maski**. His **Rummindei** pillar records the Lumbini visit.
- **Girnar / Junagadh** carries Ashoka, then Rudradaman, then Skandagupta. Three ages sit on **one** rock.
- **Pushyamitra Shunga** is recorded at **Ayodhya** for two **ashwamedhas**.
- **Heliodorus** raises the **Besnagar** Bhagavata pillar. It is **not** Pushyamitra.
- **Kharavela** is recorded at **Hathigumpha**, Udayagiri. Harsha is a common wrong option.

Satavahana, Shaka, Kushan

- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** is recorded in the **Nasik** (नासिक) prasasti of Gautami Balashri. He beats Nahapana.
- **Naganika** is recorded at **Naneghat**, with Satakarni I.
- **Rudradaman I** writes Junagadh Sanskrit prose on the Sudarsana lake repair.
- **Kanishka** has the **Rabatak** genealogy.

Gupta and after

- **Samudragupta** has the **Prayag Prashasti** of Harishena, on the **Allahabad** (इलाहाबाद) Ashokan shaft.
- He also has the **Gaya** (गया) copper plate. That plate is the **2022 trap**. It is not Sarvavarman.
- **Chandragupta II** is the usual key for the **Mehrauli** iron pillar's "Chandra."
- **Skandagupta** has the **Bhitari** pillar for the Huna war and also appears at Girnar for the Sudarsana repair after Rudradaman.
- **Ishanavarman** has **Haraha** at Barabanki, **554 CE**.
- **Ishvaravarman** has the **Jaunpur** (जौनपुर) stone.
- **Jivitagupta II** has **Deo-Baranark**. Those three 2022 pairs are correct.
- **Sarvavarman** (सर्ववर्मन) has the **Asirgarh** seal. He does **not** have the Gaya plate.
- **Pulakeshin II** has **Aihole**, composed by Ravikirti. It records the stop of Harsha.
- **Harsha** has **Banskhera**, with a signature, and **Madhuban**, a grant.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q16

The inscription of Hathigumpha is the source of information about which king?

A. Kharvela B. Ashok C. Harshavardhan D. Kanishka

Show answer

Ans: A. Hathigumpha = **Kharavela**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q91

Which of the following inscriptions gives the information about two Ashwamedha Yajnas performed by the King Pushyamitra Shung?

A. Saranath inscription B. Besnagar inscription C. Ayodhya inscription D. Hathigumpha inscription

Show answer

Ans: C. Besnagar = Heliodorus. Hathigumpha = Kharavela.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q87

Match List-I with List-II (Samudragupta's contemporary kings of South India):

A. Dhananjaya B. Nilaraja C. Ugrasena D. Vishnugopa 1. Avamukta 2. Kanchi 3. Kusthalpura 4. Palaka

A. 1 2 3 4 B. 2 1 4 3 C. 3 1 4 2 D. 4 3 2 1

Show answer

Ans: C — 3 1 4 2. Dhananjaya–Kusthalapura, Nilaraja–Avamukta, Ugrasena–Palaka, Vishnugopa–Kanchi.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q87

Which one of the following pairs is **NOT** correctly matched?

A. Ishanavarman — Harha stone inscription B. Sarvavarman — Gaya Copper Plate C. Jivitagupta II — Deva Barnark inscription D. Ishwaravarman — Jaunpur stone inscription

Show answer

Ans: B. Gaya plate ≠ Sarvavarman. Old keys that say **C** are wrong.

> **Logic:** Allahabad shaft = Ashoka first. Gupta layer = Harishena. Not "only Gupta."

11.4 Ancient Administration

Vedic tribal → Mauryan machine → Gupta/Harsha samanta | officials are the paper

- Vedic core officers are the **rajan** (राजन), the **purohita** (पुरोहित), the **senani** (सेनानी), and the **gramani** (ग्रामिणी).
- The **bhagadugha** (भागदुघ) collects revenue, the king's **bhaga** (भाग). The **sangrahitri** (संग्रहीतृ) is the treasurer. The **akshavapa** (अक्षावाप) is dice and gambling. That is the dice-officer trap.
- The **Sabha** (सभा) is the smaller assembly of elders. The **Samiti** (समिति) is the larger tribal body. The **Vidatha** (विदथ) is the kin-ritual gathering.
- There is no Samaharta and no Uparika in the Vedic list. Those names start with Maurya and Gupta.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q26

Which officer was known as **'Bhagadugha'** during Vedic administration?

A. Messenger B. Chief Officer of Forests C. Chief Officer of the Gambling Department D. Revenue Collector

Show answer

Ans: D. Gambling = Akshavapa.

Mauryan

- Mauryan administration is centralised. Officers are salaried **amatyas** (अमात्य).
- The **samaharta** (समाहर्ता) is collector-general. The **sannidhata** (सन्निधाता) is treasurer. The **rajuka** (रज्जुक) does land assessment and justice.
- The **agronomai** are Megasthenes' rural officers, revenue officers. Roads are the trap.
- The **dhamma-mahamatra** (धम्म महामात्र) appears in Rock Edict V, in the **14th** year. Statement 1, that Rahulovada is Ashoka's dhamma definition, is **false**.
- Kautilya's **saptanga** (सप्तांग) has seven limbs: swami (स्वामी), amatya (अमात्य), janapada (जनपद), durga (दुर्ग), kosha (कोष), bala (बल), and mitra (मित्र). Adhyakshas (अध्यक्ष) are department heads under that machine.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q4

The official 'Agronomai' during Mauryan age was related with which of the following field?

A. Weight and measurement B. Administrative management C. Construction of roads D. Revenue management

Show answer

Ans: D. Weights = *pautavadhyaksha*. Roads = Strabo colour, not the 2020 key.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q20

Consider the following statements with respect to Ashoka:

1. The definition of Dhamma given by Ashoka is taken from "Rahulovada-sutta".
2. In the 14th year of his coronation, Ashoka appointed a new type of staff, called Dhamma-mahamatras.

A. Both 1 and 2 B. Neither 1 nor 2 C. Only 1 D. Only 2

Show answer

Ans: D — Only 2. PE II defines dhamma. Not Rahulovada. Dhamma-mahamatras in year 14.

Gupta (गुप्त)

- Gupta administration is looser. A **samanta** (सामंत) sends tribute and troops.
- The province is **bhukti** (भुक्ति), under an **uparika** (उपरिक). The district is **vishaya** (विषय), under a **kumaramatya** (कुमारमात्य) or ayuktaka. The **sandhivigrahika** (संधिविग्रहिक) handles peace and war.

- They did **not** invent a tighter spy-state than the Mauryas.

Harsha

- Harsha reuses Gupta titles. The **mahasandhivigrahika** (महासांधिविग्रहिक) is the foreign minister. The **mahapratihara** (महाप्रतिहार) is the chamberlain. The **bhandagaradhikarana** (भाण्डागाराधिकरण) is the treasury. He still uses the **uparika** (उपरिक).
- The state is personal. It dies in 647.

Period	Revenue fact	Province / district	War-peace
Vedic	**Bhagadugha** (भागदुघ)	—	—
Mauryan	**Samaharta** (समाहर्ता) / Agronomai	Rajuka (रज्जुक) at district	King + mahamatras
Gupta	grants + bhaga	**Uparika** (उपरिक) / **Kumaramatya** (कुमारमात्य)	**Sandhivigrahika** (संधिविग्रहिक)
Harsha	grants	**Uparika** (उपरिक)	**Mahasandhivigrahika** (महासांधिविग्रहिक)

> **Logic:** Maurya is **centralised**. Gupta and Harsha run a **samanta** (feudatory) system.

11.5 Mauryan Provincial and Revenue Administration

Provinces collect; treasury stores | do not reverse Samaharta and Sannidhata

- The empire is divided into **pradeshas** (प्रदेश / chakra). Border provinces are often placed under royal princes called **kumara** (कुमार / aryaputra).
- The king's share of produce is **bhaga** (भाग). Pasture dues appear as **pindakara**. Customs and tolls appear as **sulka** (शुल्क).
- The **Samaharta** (समाहर्ता) is the chief collector of revenue. The **Sannidhata** (सन्निधाता) stores the treasury. Do not reverse collector and treasurer.
- Megasthenes' **agronomai** are rural revenue officers of the Mauryan countryside.
- The weights and measures officer is the ***pautavadhyaksha*** (पौतवाध्यक्ष).
- District land and justice work sits with the **rajuka**. Village circles run through *sthanika* and *gopa* under the wider stack: empire → province → ahara/vishaya → village.

11.6 Mauryan Spy System (*Gudhapurusha*)

Centralised watch | Arthashastra intelligence | not a Gupta machine

- Kautilya's *Arthashastra* treats spies (*gudhapurusha*) as part of the **centralised** Mauryan state.
- Spy types in coaching lists include secret agents, wandering ascetics, and household informers.
- Their jobs are to test officials, watch the frontier, and gather political and military intelligence.

- The Gupta and Harsha ages do **not** run the same paid spy-state image; they lean on feudatory *samanta* ties instead.

11.7 Gupta and Harsha Official Ladder

Bhukti → vishaya | titles inflate under Harsha | samanta land grip

- A Gupta province is a **bhukti** under an **uparika**. A district is a **vishaya** under a **kumaramatya**.
- The **sandhivigrahika** handles peace and war. Harsha reuses the same titles at a higher grade as **mahasandhivigrahika**, **mahapratihara**, and **bhandagaradhikarana**.
- Feudatories are **samanta / mahasamanta**. Land grants (*agrahara*, *brahmadeya*) thicken after the Guptas and under Harsha.
- Mauryan rule pays salaried **amatyas**. Gupta and Harsha rule is looser and more personal; the machine weakens when the king dies.

11.8 Foreign Accounts on Ancient Administration

Traveller age first | then the admin observation

- **Megasthenes**, under Chandragupta Maurya, records seven castes through a Greek lens, names the **agronomai**, and describes six city boards and six army boards.
- **Fa-Hien** (फाह्यान), under Chandragupta II, notes comparatively light punishments and visible Buddhist patronage in Gupta north India.
- **Hiuen Tsang** (ह्वेनसांग), under Harsha, praises roads and hospices; elephant numbers in his account are colour, not a census.
- **I-tsing**, after Harsha, focuses on monastic rules and Nalanda life rather than a new imperial office list.

Traveller	Age	Admin observation
Megasthenes	Chandragupta Maurya	seven castes (Greek lens), agronomai, city boards
Fa-Hien	Chandragupta II	light punishments, Buddhist patronage visible
Hiuen Tsang	Harsha	good roads, hospices; elephant numbers = colour
I-tsing	Post-Harsha	monastic rules at Nalanda

UP Focus

Fact	Place
Ayodhya inscription	Pushyamitra ashwamedha
Prayag / Allahabad shaft	Ashoka + Harishena

Fact	Place
Haraha	Barabanki — Ishanavarman
Jaunpur stone	Ishvaravarman
Bhitari	Ghazipur belt — Skandagupta
Banskhera	Shahjahanpur — Harsha signature
Besnagar	**MP** — Heliodorus pillar